MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 3: Ran - Akira Kurosawa

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Akira Kurosawa’s Ran transforms King Lear into a Japanese cinematic tragedy about divided power, inherited violence, pride, and fragile reconciliation.

Start with a picture

An old leader thinks he can hand over command yet keep obedience and respect. His children see the transfer differently. Now imagine the conflict told through castles, distant landscapes, colour, movement, and sound instead of a stage speech alone.

1. Film and source

Ran was released in 1985. Kurosawa draws on King Lear while also engaging Japanese historical and cultural materials. Calling it “Lear in Japan” is a starting point, not a complete explanation.

Medium matters: a camera can select distance, frame several actions, and separate what is seen from what is heard. A film adaptation does not simply add scenery to a play.

2. Main figures

Hidetora Ichimonji is the ageing warlord. His sons are Taro, Jiro, and Saburo. Saburo’s honest warning challenges his father’s plan and brings banishment. Kyoami, the fool, speaks truths that power struggles to hear. Tango remains loyal. Lady Kaede’s revenge and Lady Sué’s different response to suffering reveal the past violence behind the present crisis. Tsurumaru also embodies its human cost.

Do not force every character into a perfect one-to-one match with a Lear figure. The adaptation changes relationships and motives.

3. Follow the plot

Hidetora divides authority among his sons, expecting continued honour. The flattering acceptance of the elder sons contrasts with Saburo’s resistance. Once power has moved, Hidetora finds his remaining position insecure.

Conflict among the heirs escalates into war and the destruction of his security. Wandering, humiliation, and mental collapse expose his dependence. His own history of conquest returns through survivors and avengers. A reunion with Saburo offers a possibility of repair, but

further violence destroys it. The ending leaves devastation rather than a restored harmonious kingdom.

4. Madness and history

Like Lear, Hidetora loses the structures that previously supported his identity. Yet Ran makes the memory of his earlier brutality especially important. His suffering does not erase his responsibility for the suffering of others.

A good comparison asks both what the rulers share and what Kurosawa changes about their moral histories.

5. Film techniques to analyse

- **Colour:** distinguishes forces and can connect characters with contrasting emotional or political patterns.
- **Long shot:** places a human figure within a landscape that can make power seem small or precarious.
- **Framing and movement:** arrange competing forces and expose the distance between command and consequence.
- **Sound and silence:** the assault on the castle is famous for a controlled relationship between music, image, and withheld battle noise.
- **Performance:** stylised posture and facial presentation can evoke Japanese theatrical traditions, including Noh.

Do not invent a timestamp. Identify the sequence and check the copy you watch.

6. The fool and the avenger

Kyoami’s licence to mock can expose truths a ruler would reject from others. Kaede’s actions make revenge a political force rooted in destruction inflicted on her family. She is not merely a generic wicked woman or an exact duplicate of one of Lear’s daughters.

Quick check

1. What does Saburo’s banishment reveal? **Power can mistake truthful warning for disloyalty.**
2. Does Hidetora’s suffering make his past irrelevant? **No.**
3. Why discuss sound and framing? **They create meaning that cannot be explained by plot summary alone.**

Build an exam answer

1. Establish the Lear parallels without demanding exact matches.
2. Explain Hidetora’s violent past and its return.
3. Analyse Kaede, the fool, or another changed role.

4. Choose a sequence for colour, framing, and sound analysis.
5. Evaluate the ending’s relation to reconciliation.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not give the whole ending a happy reconciliation or equate Kaede mechanically with Goneril or Regan. A film essay needs cinematic evidence.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How does Ran transform Shakespearean tragedy through history and cinematic form?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Ran retains the powerful situation of an ageing ruler who discovers that the transfer of authority cannot preserve the obedience he expects. Saburo’s rejection and later loyalty recall Cordelia’s place within King Lear, while Hidetora’s exposure and mental collapse develop the source’s investigation of identity after power. These parallels make comparison productive, but the film’s force also depends on what it adds and rearranges.

Hidetora’s earlier violence returns through the people whose lives it damaged. The tragedy therefore concerns not only a mistaken judgement about children but the instability of a political order created through conquest. Lady Kaede’s vengeance and the suffering associated with Sué and Tsurumaru broaden the field of consequences. Sympathy for the old ruler does not require forgetting this history.

Cinematic form gives the conflict a distinct scale. Colour differentiates forces and relationships, while distant framing can reduce the apparent mastery of individual figures. The relation between visual violence and the score in the castle assault produces an effect that a summary of events cannot reproduce. Stylised acting and carefully arranged landscapes transform psychological and political conflict into a visual pattern.

The film’s ending makes reconciliation painfully fragile. Recognition may occur, but it cannot undo the accumulated damage or guarantee survival. A strong answer consequently treats adaptation as a transformation of ethical emphasis and artistic method. It explains how a Shakespearean structure becomes a new encounter with violence, authority, and human vulnerability through Japanese cultural materials and cinema.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Compare the film’s depiction of madness with Shakespeare’s portrayal of Lear’s storm-tossed exile.
2. Analyse the role of Kyoami as the fool and his function in highlighting truth and loyalty.
3. Discuss how colour design and cinematography convey themes of chaos and order.
4. Examine Lady Kaede’s character as a fusion of Goneril and Regan and her impact on the narrative.
5. Evaluate the film’s ending and its interpretation of reconciliation and loss